SHIWEI LIAO

Doctoral Applicant | Media & Communication | Generative AI | Communicative Authority | Digital Intermediation
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RESEARCH PROFILE

University of Melbourne Master of Global Media Communication graduate (WAM 80.38) researching how generative AI reshapes the communicative roles and authority claims of digital intermediaries. My proposed doctoral project compares Doubao Aixue and Xiaohe AI Doctor within ByteDance's Chinese AI service environment, with the main Doubao app as a common reference for general-purpose explanation and source organisation. My work connects platform studies, communicative AI and relational accounts of authority.

EDUCATION

Master of Global Media Communication 2023 - 2025

The University of Melbourne, Faculty of Arts - Melbourne, Australia

- WAM 80.38 (H1); completed July 2025. Minor Thesis: *Governing via AI Broadcasting in the Digital Era* - 87/100 (H1), approximately 12,750 words; supervised by Dr Wilfred Wang.
- Used Fairclough's critical discourse analysis and NVivo-assisted coding to examine how Chinese AI policy and CCTV's 2024 AI Gala construct technological legitimacy and state-media authority, establishing my broader interest in AI-mediated institutional voice, legitimacy and authority.
- Selected H1 results: Global Communication: Theory & Research (88); Media and Communications Thesis (87); Media Convergence and Digital Culture (86); Digital Politics (85); Researching Audiences and Reception (85).

Bachelor of Broadcast Announcing and Anchoring Art 2017 - 2022

Communication University of Zhejiang - Hangzhou, China

- Cumulative average 87.42/100. Training combined broadcast presentation, interviewing, media production and communication practice, providing an early foundation in institutional voice and mediated public communication.

SELECTED AWARDS

- Zhejiang Provincial Government Scholarship.
- First-class Scholarship, Communication University of Zhejiang.
- Outstanding Award, National Innovation and Entrepreneurship Programme for College Students (Yi Shu Yi Ying project).

PROPOSED DOCTORAL RESEARCH DIRECTION

Generative AI, Digital Intermediation and Communicative Authority

- Core question: How does generative AI reshape the communicative role and authority of digital intermediaries?
- **Proposed doctoral study:** An embedded comparison of Doubao Aixue and Xiaohe AI Doctor as two specialised analytical units within a bounded ByteDance Chinese AI service environment. The main Doubao app provides a systematic common reference in matched educational and health scenarios, not a third equivalent professional case.
- **Analytical focus:** How sources, explanations, judgements and subsequent action configure communicative roles; how educational and medical authority claims are supported, challenged and bounded; and how those claims circulate and are negotiated across official, editorial media, creator and public discourse.
- **Media and communication focus:** Connects platform intermediation, communicative AI and professional authority while distinguishing visible role performance from documented recognition, and interface evidence from unverified backend mechanisms.

METHODS & RESEARCH SKILLS

- **Established:** critical discourse analysis; qualitative content analysis; semi-structured interviewing; NVivo-assisted coding; keyword-frequency/co-occurrence analysis; corpus organisation.
- **Current methodological development:** repeated structured walkthrough in matched scenarios; authority challenges; qualitative and discursive interface analysis; longitudinal researcher documentation; descriptive content analysis and platform/media/public discourse analysis. The proposed design combines these with adult critical-incident interviews in a qualitative-dominant mixed-methods study.

SELECTED RESEARCH PROJECTS

Doubao Aixue and Xiaohe AI Doctor: Communicative Roles and Authority Claims
Current research pilot
Exploratory walkthrough and interface/discourse research comparing educational and health-related role claims, source presentation and responsibility boundaries, with the main Doubao app as a common reference. This pilot informs the design of a proposed embedded comparative study within ByteDance's Chinese AI service environment.

Seeing the City Through AI Glasses
Media Convergence and Digital Culture - 86/100, H1
Analysed AI smart glasses as wearable urban media infrastructure, extending my research from institutional AI discourse toward interfaces, media infrastructures and body-space-data relations.

Media Marketing and Crisis Discourse on TikTok
Researching Media & Communications - 80/100, H1
Compared BBC and Guardian coverage of TikTok's data-privacy crisis through qualitative content analysis and NVivo-assisted coding, demonstrating training in platform crisis discourse, media framing and qualitative coding.

Navigating the Privacy Paradox: TikTok's Role in the Digital Public Sphere
Researching Audiences and Reception - 85/100, H1
Used semi-structured interviewing and framing theory to examine how algorithmic curation shapes privacy perception, providing direct qualitative interviewing experience relevant to platform governance research.

MANUSCRIPT IN DEVELOPMENT

From AI Gala to Spring Festival Gala: The Infrastructuralisation of AI Discourse in Chinese State Media
In preparation
Article manuscript extending the minor thesis by examining how AI shifts from a visible object of technological legitimation to an embedded production condition in Chinese state-media ritual.

RELEVANT PROFESSIONAL & TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Online Test Preparation Instructor (IELTS and PTE) 2023 - present
Freelance / Online
- Deliver one-to-one and small-group online instruction, including lesson planning, formative feedback, speaking and writing support, and individual learning guidance.
- Provides sustained teaching and student-support experience relevant to future university tutoring and sessional teaching.

Freelance Short-form Video Producer 2021 - 2023
Independent client work - China
- Sourced small-business clients independently and produced promotional short-form video content for Douyin, from concept development and client communication to on-location shooting and post-production editing.
- Applied end-to-end multimedia skills developed through broadcast training, including field interviewing, copy/script preparation, visual storytelling, shooting, presenting/voice work where required, and editing.

Media and Communications Intern 2018 - 2019
Hangzhou TV Group / Anji News Group - Hangzhou and Anji, China
- Conducted on-location public interviews and supported live-broadcast, short-video and media-production workflows in state-affiliated news organisations.
- Newsroom experience informs later research on institutional voice, state-media authority and mediated public communication.

RESEARCH INTERESTS & COLLABORATION

Generative AI and communicative authority; digital intermediation; communicative AI; platform governance; educational and medical authority claims; institutional and platform discourse; platform and interface studies; Chinese digital and state media; AI-mediated learning and health communication; qualitative and critical methods. Interested in collaborative research on AI-mediated services, institutional communication and professional authority.